



THE BATTLE AGAINST CLIMATE CHANGE

THE KYOTO PROTOCOL (2005)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Environmental law

BEFORE

1988 The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) is established.

1992 At the Earth Summit in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, the first international goals for emissions reduction are adopted.

1997 The US Senate refuses to ratify the Kyoto Protocol, on the basis that developing countries are exempt from compliance.

AFTER

2009 The Copenhagen Summit ends in stalemate—no legally binding commitments are made.

2015 The Paris Agreement sets nonbinding targets to limit the global temperature rise to 3.6°F (2°C) by 2100.

2017 President Donald Trump withdraws the US from the Paris Agreement.

The Kyoto Protocol, adopted in 1997 and enacted in 2005, was the first agreement between industrialized nations to make defined reductions in their emissions of greenhouse gases. The Protocol built on the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), adopted at the Rio Earth Summit in June 1992. The signatories to the UNFCCC have met annually since 1995 at Conferences of the Parties (COPs). The targets of the Kyoto Protocol are binding under international law.

In signing the Protocol, parties acknowledged that emissions from burning fossil fuels are leading to potentially catastrophic increases in the world's temperature, with predicted consequences including rising sea levels; species extinction and biodiversity loss; and increases in extreme weather events such as floods, droughts, and wildfires. The goal of limiting the increase in global temperature to less than 3.6°F (2°C) by 2100, as set out in the Paris Agreement at the 2015 COP, would demand unprecedented efforts.

Given the monetary cost of the reforms needed, not to mention the lifestyle changes required, results have been mixed. While some countries have met their targets, political leaders have clashed over the complex issue of the relative responsibilities of developed (signatory) nations and of major emerging economies. Meanwhile, global emissions and temperatures have continued to rise. ■



Stabilization of greenhouse gas concentrations in the atmosphere [to] prevent dangerous anthropogenic interference with the climate system.

Objective (Article 2) of the UNFCCC



See also: The United Nations and International Court of Justice 212–219 ■ The Endangered Species Act 264–265 ■ The World Network of Biosphere Reserves 270–271